

African nation in the competition. The claim can be justified to a great extent, as the squad has the presence of veterans like Sadio Mane, Kalidou Koulibaly and Idrissa Gana Gueye combined with the liveliness of Iliman Ndiaye, Nicolas Jackson and Pape Matar Sarr.

But the side's greatest strength comes in the form of head coach Pape Thiaw, who knows a thing or two about this competition after being part of the 2002 Senegal squad that reached the quarterfinals while beating holders France on the way.

With each of the above-mentioned teams looking more menacing than the others, Iraq will be hoping it is no pushover and will have a say in how things pan out at the end of the group stage.

Ironically, the West Asian nation was the final team to book its place at the World Cup after beating Bolivia in the intercontinental playoffs, thanks to head coach Graham Arnold, who guided Australia at the previous edition in Qatar. And, with the top two as well as the eight best third-placed teams advancing to the knockouts, Iraq is expected not to go down without a fight in its first appearance since 1986.



Sadio Mane (Senegal)

When Sadio Mane made his move to Saudi Arabia in the summer of 2023, many would have expected the 34-year-old's career to slowly fizzle out. But 51 goals and 25 assists in 129 appearances since, including a league triumph this season, all but show that the former Liverpool forward is ready to lead Senegal in what could be his final attempt at attaining global glory.



Aymen Hussein (Iraq)

It would not be an overstatement to say that Aymen Hussein carried Iraq to the World Cup. His nine goals on the road to qualification, including the winner against Bolivia in the intercontinental playoffs final, underline the 30-year-old's impact on the side. And in a tournament where surprises are never far away, having his experience up front adds to Iraq's chances of pulling off the impossible.

SQUADS

France

Goalkeepers: Mike Maignan, Brice Samba, Robin Risser

Defenders: Lucas Digne, Malo Gusto, Lucas Hernandez, Theo Hernandez, Ibrahima Konate, Jules Kounde, Maxence Lacroix, William Saliba, Dayot Upamecano

Midfielders: N'Golo Kante, Manu Kone, Adrien Rabiot, Aurelien Tchouameni, Warren Zaire-Emery

Forwards: Kylian Mbappe, Ousmane Dembele, Marcus Thuram, Michael Olise, Bradley Barcola, Rayan Cherki, Desire Doue, Jean-Philippe Mateta, Maghnes Akliouche

Norway

Goalkeepers: Ørjan Håskjold Nyland, Egil Selvik, Sander Tangvik

Defenders: Kristoffer Vassbakk Ajer, Fredrik Bjørkan, Henrik Falchener, Sondre Langås, Torbjørn Heggem, Marcus Holmgren Pedersen, Julian Ryerson, David Møller Wolfe, Leo Østigård

Midfielders: Thelonious Aasgaard, Fredrik Aursnes, Patrick Berg, Sander Berge, Oscar Bobb, Jens Petter Hauge, Antonio Nusa, Andreas Schjelderup, Morten Thorsby, Kristian Thorstvedt, Martin Ødegaard

Forwards: Erling Haaland, Jørgen Strand Larsen, Alexander Sørloth

Senegal

Goalkeepers: Mory Diaw, Yehvann Diouf, Edouard Mendy

Defenders: Krepin Diatta, El Hadji Malick Diouf, Ismail Jakobs, Kalidou Koulibaly, Antoine Mendy, Moussa Niakhate, Mamadou Sarr, Abdoulaye Seck

Midfielders: Lamine Camara, Pape Matar Sarr, Habib Diarra, Idrissa Gana Gueye, Pape Gueye, Pathe Ciss, Bara Sapoko Ndiaye

Forwards: Sadio Mane, Nicolas Jackson, Ismaila Sarr, Iliman Ndiaye, Assane Diao, Bamba Dieng, Cherif Ndiaye, Ibrahim Mbaye

Iraq

Goalkeepers: Ahmed Basil, Jalal Hassan, Fahad Talib

Defenders: Hussein Ali, Merchas Doski, Akam Hashem, Frans Putros, Mustafa Saadoon, Rebin Sulaka, Zaid Tahseen, Ahmed Yahya, Manaf Younis, Zaid Ismail

Midfielders: Amir Al Ammari, Youssef Aryn, Ibrahim Bayesh, Marko Farji, Zidane Iqbal, Ahmed Qasim, Aimar Sher, Kevin Yakob

Forwards: Mohanad Ali, Aymen Hussein, Ali Al Hamadi, Ali Yousef, Ali Jassim